

Design Systems for Marketing Teams: What to Standardize



Shrouk Omar
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Marketing teams waste hundreds of hours recreating assets from scratch — mismatched fonts, off-brand colors, inconsistent button styles. A well-built design system eliminates all of that. Here's exactly what to standardize, and why.

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1 Why marketing teams need design systems

Most marketing teams operate in a state of creative chaos. Designers, copywriters, social media managers, and campaign leads all produce content — but rarely from the same playbook. The result? Brand inconsistency that erodes audience trust over time.

A design system isn't just a style guide. It's a living, shared library of decisions: how your brand speaks, looks, and behaves across every touchpoint. When built right, it dramatically reduces production time and eliminates the endless cycle of "which logo should I use?"

Companies with strong design systems launch campaigns up to 3× faster — and see measurably higher brand recognition within 12 months of implementation.

2 The 5 core elements to standardize

Not everything needs to be locked down. Standardize the elements with the highest brand impact and the most repetition across teams.



Typography

Font families, sizes, weights, line heights for every context



Color Palette

Primary, secondary, neutral tones with exact hex values



Logo Usage

Approved formats, clearspace rules, forbidden uses



Image Style

Photography treatment, illustration tone, do/don't examples



UI Components

Buttons, forms, CTAs, cards — pre-built and approved

3 Components vs. guidelines: what's the difference?

Teams often confuse the two. Guidelines are the rules — components are the pre-built, reusable assets that follow those rules. You need both.

Element	Guideline example	Component example	Reusable?
Typography	"Use DM Sans at 16px for body"	Pre-set text styles in Figma	Yes
Color	"Primary blue is #185FA5"	Color tokens in design file	Yes
Buttons	"Rounded corners, 40px height"	Button component with states	Yes
Tone of voice	"Direct, not jargon-heavy"	Copy examples per channel	Partial
Ad templates	"Logo always top-left"	Locked Figma ad templates	Yes

4 Common standardization mistakes

Even well-intentioned design system efforts fail. Here are the pitfalls that derail marketing teams most often:

- ✓ **Over-documenting.** A 120-page PDF no one opens isn't a system. Keep it scannable and actionable.
- ✓ **No ownership.** Someone must own the system. Without a maintainer, it goes stale within months.
- ✓ **Designing in a vacuum.** Systems built without input from the teams using them get ignored.
- ✓ **Treating it as a one-time project.** A design system must evolve with the brand, not be frozen after launch.
- ✓ **Standardizing everything.** Leave room for creativity. Lock the core; flex the expression.

5 How to roll it out across your team

A successful rollout is 20% design and 80% communication. Follow these phases for smooth adoption:

Phase 1 — Audit

Collect all existing assets. Identify inconsistencies and the most-used components.

Phase 2 — Define

Agree on the core decisions: palette, fonts, key components. Get stakeholder sign-off.

Phase 3 — Build

Create the Figma library, token files, and documentation hub. Start small — 20 components beats 200 stubs.

Phase 4 — Train

Run workshops. Show how the system saves time. Make adoption feel easy, not policed.

Pro tip: launch with a "quick wins" kit — just the top 10 most-used assets standardized. Momentum matters more than completeness at the start.

Ready to build your marketing design system?

Download the free checklist and get started with the 20 decisions every marketing team should make first.

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